The Iqbal Test

Can we use AI and still become ourselves?



Junaid Qadir, Qatar University

Iqbal Day, Embassy of Pakistan, Doha

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TWO VERY OLD QUESTIONS

What is intelligence?

ذہانت کیا ہے؟



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Can machines think?

کیا مشینیں سوچ سکتی ہیں؟

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The “Turing Test” of Artificial Intelligence

مصنوعی ذہانت کی کسوٹی



Alan Turing, 1950, first sentence

“I propose to consider the question,
‘Can machines think?’”

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A few lines later (Mind, 1950, p. 433)

“I shall replace the question
by another …”

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1950 Imitate

Turing’s imitation game:
can a machine pass for a person
in written answers?

1955–56 Compute

Dartmouth gives the field its name:
intelligence, “so precisely described”
that a machine can simulate it

2025 Passed?

One study: in five-minute chats,
GPT-4.5 was judged human
73% of the time. Still debated.

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Erik Brynjolfsson, 2022

Build AI to imitate people, and it replaces them.

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If intelligence is only computation, are we merely slower information processors?

The seeing heart

فَتَكُونَ لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ يَعْقِلُونَ بِهَآ

سورة الحج: ٤٦

"Hearts to understand" (al-Hajj 22:46, tr. Abdel Haleem). Al-Qurtubi: understanding is ascribed to the heart "because it is its seat".

BOTH / AND

Khirad · Aql خرد · عقل

the light of the eye · آنکھ کا نور

Takes reality piece by piece: analyses, measures, calculates. Science and AI extend it.

AND

Ishq · Dil عشق · دل

the light of the heart · دل کا نور

Takes reality whole: worth, meaning, purpose.

Not anti-reason: "a higher kind of intellect".

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BAL-I JIBRIL, 1935

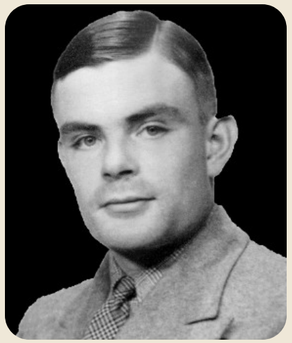
دل بینا بھی کر خدا سے طلب
آنکھ کا نور دل کا نور نہیں

Ask God for a seeing heart as well: the light of the eye is not the light of the heart.

The Iqbal Test for the AI era

خودی کی کسوٹی

1950



Turing’s test examines the machine

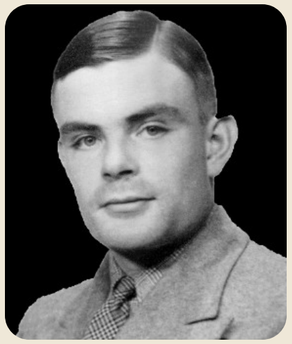
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Only machines take it.

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Turing’s test examines the machine

Can it pass for a person?

Only machines take it.

2026 · OXCIS



The Iqbal Test examines the person

Working with the machine, am I still becoming a self?

Its effect on khudi: of the person and the community.

The criterion is Iqbal’s: does it guard the self? (Zarb-i Kalim, “Din o Hunar”)

Our technological age: brilliant, restless and absent دَورِ حاضر: باذوق، بے فراغ، بے حضور

From the nazm “Pir o Murid” (Bal-i Jibril): the disciple, Iqbal himself, speaks to his guide, Rumi

On our age · دَورِ حاضر

دَورِ حاضر مستِ چنگ و بے سُرور
بے ثبات و بے یقین و بے حضور

The present age: drunk on the harp, yet joyless;
unsteady, without certainty, without presence.

On the self · خودی

بے حضور و باذوق و بے فراغ
اپنے نخچیروں کے ہاتھوں داغ داغ

The self: without presence, brilliant, restless;
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Do we hunt our machines, or are we their prey?

Are we becoming the tools of our tools?

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غیب سے غفلت

At the root: ghaflah, heedlessness of al-ghayb

the unseen reality of the human being, and of the cosmos

A Quranic source for the philosophy of khudi

فلسفۂ خودی کا قرآنی ماخذ

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وَلَا تَكُونُوا۟ كَٱلَّذِينَ نَسُوا۟ ٱللَّهَ فَأَنسَىٰهُمْ أَنفُسَهُمْ

“Do not be like those who forget God, so God causes them to forget their own souls.”

Quran 59:19, first part · Surah al-Hashr · tr. Abdel Haleem

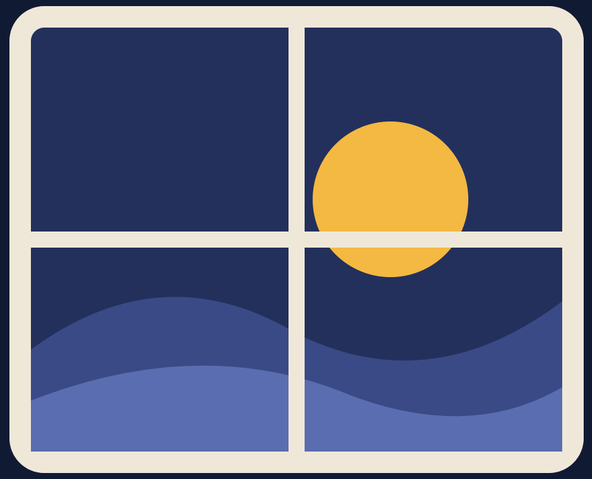
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We reach reality through forms, as we see through a window.

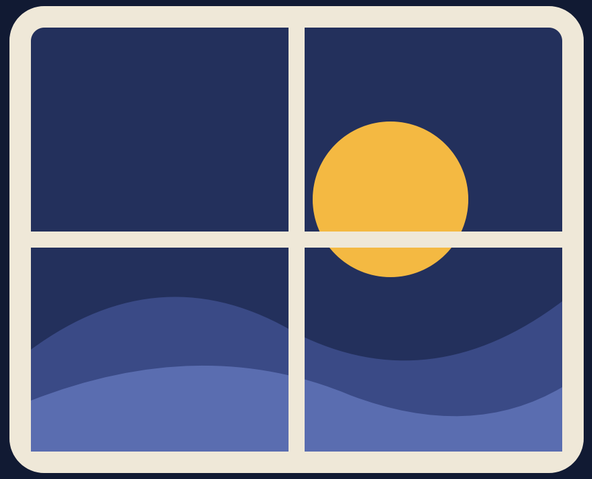
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The mistake is to think the window is all there is, and that nothing lies beyond it.

Khudi: an ideal gathers the self

تعمیرِ خودی



Rafiuddin's image: the coach is the self, the horses are its desires, the coachman is its love for the ideal.

Khudi: an ideal gathers the self

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HOW THE SELF LEARNS TO HOLD THE REINS: THREE STAGES IN ASRAR-I KHUDI

1 Obedience

Itaat · اطاعت

binding oneself to the divine Law, as the camel bears its load

2 Self-control

Zabt-e nafs · ضبطِ نفس

mastering one's own desires

3 Vicegerency

Niyabat-e Ilahi · نیابتِ الٰہی

acting on earth as God's deputy

Strengtheners of khudi

استحکامِ خودی

Ideal · نصب العین

aims born of desire (arzu)

ما ز تخلیقِ مقاصد زندہ ایم
از شعاعِ آرزو تابندہ ایم

We live by creating aims;
we shine with the ray of desire.

Asrar-i Khudi

Love · عشق

that keeps the ideal alive

عقل و دل و نگاہ کا
مُرشدِ اوّلیں ہے عشق

Love is the first guide
of intellect, heart and sight.

Bal-i Jibril, “Zauq o Shauq”

Guide · مرشد

with vision (nazar) and presence (huzur)

صد کتاب آموزی از اہل ہنر
خوشتر آن درسی کہ گیری از نظر

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The question of Sarah Blaffer Hrdy’s TED talk

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طفل میں بُو آئے کیا ماں باپ کے اطوار کی / دُودھ تو ڈبّے کا ہے، تعلیم ہے سرکار کی

What can a child take from his parents’ ways? The milk is from a tin, the schooling from the state. (Akbar Allahabadi)

Strengtheners of khudi

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The khudi of the self and the community

فرد اور ملّت



Personal mastery
Build a strong self

Shared vision
Bind it to a common ideal

The khudi of the self and the community

فرد اور ملّت

Book one · 1915

اسرارِ خودی

Asrar-i Khudi

Khudi

Personal mastery

Build a strong self

Book two · 1918

رموزِ بے خودی

Rumuz-i Bekhudi

Bekhudi

Shared vision

Bind it to a common ideal

فرد از توحید لاهوتی شود
ملت از توحید جبروتی شود

By tawhid the person rises to the divine realm (lahut); by tawhid a people rises to majesty (jabarut). (Javid Nama, the Divine Voice)

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This angelic wisdom, this divine knowledge: if it is no cure for the pain of the Haram, it is nothing at all. (Zarb-i Kalim)

Life’s test: will the drop become a pearl?

زندگی کا امتحان: کیا قطرہ گُہر بنے گا؟

The old image: a drop of April rain, held inside the oyster’s shell, slowly becomes a pearl.

زندگانی ہے صدَف، قطرۂ نیساں ہے خودی
وہ صدَف کیا کہ جو قطرے کو گُہر کر نہ سکے

Iqbal: life is the shell; the self is the raindrop.
What use is a shell that cannot turn the drop into a pearl? (Zarb-i Kalim)

Life’s test: will the drop become a pearl?

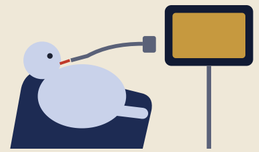
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تن آسانی



Tan-asani, the love of ease: WALL-E (2008)

A tool that removes every difficulty also removes what forms us.

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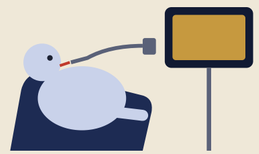
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THREE WEAKENERS OF KHUDI · ضعفِ خودی کے اسباب

Distraction
scatters the self

خودی کی موت ہے اندیشہ ہائے گوناگوں

Death of the self: a mind pulled many ways.

Outsourcing
leaves it dependent

از سؤال آشفتہ اجزای خودی

By asking, the parts of the self come apart.

Conditioning
reshapes what we want

تھا جو 'ناخُوب'، بتدریج وہی 'خُوب' ہُوا

What was bad became, by degrees, good.

Iqbal’s Test in Conclusion

اقبال کی کسوٹی



اگر خودی کی حفاظت کریں تو عینِ حیات
نہ کر سکیں تو سراپا فسُون و افسَانہ

If they guard the self, they are life itself; if not, spell and fable. (Zarb-i Kalim, “Din o Hunar”)

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THREE QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

Fard · فرد
Able, or dependent?

Millat · ملّت
Closer, or disconnected?

Nasb-ul-ain · نصب العین
A higher aim, and God?

کسے نہیں ہے تمنّائے سَروری، لیکن خودی کی موت ہو جس میں وہ سَروری کیا ہے!
Who does not long for mastery? But what mastery is it, in which the self dies? (Bal-i Jibril)

Iqbal's Test in Conclusion

اقبال کی کسوٹی



اگر خودی کی حفاظت کریں تو عینِ حیات
نہ کر سکیں تو سراپا فسُون و افسَانہ

If they guard the self, they are life itself; if not, spell and fable. (Zarb-i Kalim, "Din o Hunar")

THREE QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

Fard · فرد
Able, or dependent?

Millat · ملّت
Closer, or disconnected?

Nasb-ul-ain · نصب العین
A higher aim, and God?

کسے نہیں ہے تمنّائے سَروری، لیکن خودی کی موت ہو جس میں وہ سَروری کیا ہے!
Who does not long for mastery? But what mastery is it, in which the self dies? (Bal-i Jibril)

Thank you · شکریہ | **Junaid Qadir** jqadir@qu.edu.qa